



What versos can tell you

Christies outline the range of information that can be gleaned from versos passed through their auctions. <https://digit.in/feb20-45>



The Diptych

At times, two paintings can be attached and presented as the same artwork. Find out about these pieces. <https://digit.in/feb20-46>

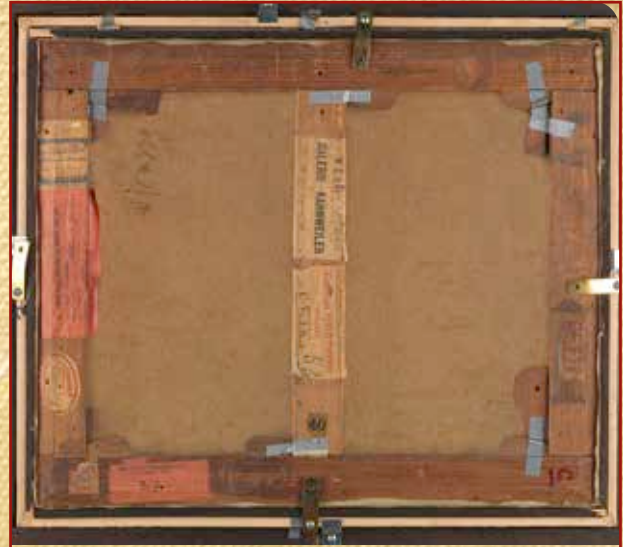
GEEK-KEY

OPPOSING (#15)

The oil on linen work by Frederick Hammersley has a verso with a number of missing labels, as well as a partially removed one on the top right. The surviving label of the heritage gallery has important details such as the name, medium and date washed out, with barely legible red ink. Mysteriously, there is a #11 in blue ink on this label. Next to it are two untouched labels with the artist's name, the #15 noted in the date field, the dimensions of the painting, and full address of the artist. This painting also has an arrow accompanied with the letters "top", to indicate which side of the painting faces upwards, which we guess is essential here, unlike the Mona Lisa as Opposing #15 is an abstract geometric work. A piece of tape stretches across the middle, and there are spill marks from some mysterious liquid.



Credit: Los Angeles Modern Auctions



Credit: Met Museum

THE OIL MILL

Pablo Picasso's The Oil Mill has labels showing the exhibition history of the painting, as well as its previous owners. Towards the top right corner is a label for Roger Dutilleul, listing his Parisian address as 48 bis, rue de la Monceau. Dutilleul was one of the regular patrons Daniel-Henry Kahnweiler's gallery, and frequently purchased paintings from the gallery. The middle of the painting has a label for Kahnweiler's gallery, including the address on 28, Rue Vignon. Below that is a label noting a loan of the painting to Galerie Georges Petit for a 1933 exhibition by Dutilleul. The labels for the 1995 XXV Biennale di Venezia exhibition can be seen just below Dutilleul's turquoise collection sticker. Along the edges are many abandoned screw holes and a crack.

UNTITLED [DRAWING FOR PG]

Although Untitled [Drawing for PG] is one of Jackson Pollock's more decipherable works, with distinct forms and figures of what appear to be nightmarish flora and fauna, the back serves as a reply to a common issue raised by casual critics. The verso has truly random squiggles, splashes and marks caused by the mixture of same media used on the recto, including a black pen, green and black ink washes, red colour pencil and an orange watercolour pencil. This shows that Pollock did not randomly create patterns using a range of painting supplies, and pass it off as "art". The artwork was created on laid paper, and the back has no labels indicating the provenance, address of the artist or exhibition history like most of the other works in the list. However, on the top right corner, in barely legible handwriting, there seems to be a list of materials used to create the work. 



Credit: The Morgan Library and Museum